possessions, but sublimated these in a larger purpose. (Kama even has its own *shastra*, Vatsyayana's Kama Sutra). Hinduism accommodated the acknowledgement of worldly desires within the quest for the eternal. As Radhakrishnan postulated, Hinduism 'binds together the kingdoms of earth and heaven'. Indeed, it is no coincidence that Hindu gods are all married; they are depicted with consorts, each of whom, like the gods and goddesses themselves, have multiple aspects and manifestations. It is a striking feature of Hinduism that our gods can be susceptible to desire; they are depicted falling for *apsara*s and seducing sages' wives. Lord Shiva even fell for Vishnu in the transformed appearance of the ethereally beautiful Mohini. Prudery appears to have been imported into Hindu social attitudes only in reaction to the Muslim invasions and Victorian colonial rule.

Hindus pursue their quest for the eternal—the search for 'the light beyond the darkness'—through three types of activity: *jnana* or the quest for knowledge, not merely theoretical learning but in the form of realised experience which leads to wisdom; *bhakti* or devotion, expressed principally through prayer, fasting, temple rituals and sacrifice, but also through meditation and self-interrogation; and karma or action and service in the fulfilment of *dharma*. (Karma is a concept that is variously translated as action, fate or destiny, and causality; it means all three, though the meaning depends on the context in which the phrase is used.)

Bhakti is of course the most popular path, and the easiest for most people to pursue, since a capacity for worship comes inborn in all of us. Purists categorise Hindu worship in a taxonomy that runs like this: the most simple Hindus worship spirits and animist forces; the next level of ordinary Hindus worship their own ancestors, popular deities and gurus or godmen; the level above that worships incarnations like Rama, Krishna, or Buddha; above this level are those who worship a personal god, or *ishta-devta;* and highest of all are those Hindus who worship the Absolute, in the form of Brahman. Those who worship the *ishta-devta* or personal *bhagavan* (in other words those trying to reach Brahman through a divine intermediary) must settle for a somewhat lower place in the hierarchy of spiritual yearning than those who seek Brahman for itself, in the quest for ultimate self-realisation. A verse from the *Kena*